In these circumstances, it would be difficult to make a case for transferring the responsibility of defending Gilgit to Maharaja Hari Singh. It was largely to keep the area out of Hari Singh's hands that the Gilgit lease had been secured in the first place. Yet here was Mountbatten apparently abandoning this vital outpost and handing it back to Hari Singh. This was a paradox which only made sense on the assumption that the new lessees of the Gilgit lease would be based not in Srinagar and Jammu, but either in New Delhi or in Karachi.

Did Mountbatten run the developments in Sinkiang past Ismay? Did Ismay accept the inevitability of the rapidly changing Central Asian dynamic? Was there a split in the opinions of these men? If Mountbatten had been willing to let Pakistan be the guardian of the Gilgit Agency and the high passes of the Karakoram, he could well have left the Gilgit lease alone. The original contract was between the state of Jammu and Kashmir and the Government of India and the lapse of paramountcy upon the transfer of power had nothing to do with it. There was no reason why it would lapse automatically in October 1947 or earlier. For added safety, the extension of the lease could have been carried out by a simple standstill agreement which would ensure that even if Jammu and Kashmir acceded to Pakistan, the tenancy created as a consequence of the lease would also pass to Pakistan.

Was Ismay convinced by Mountbatten's reasoning? Did Mountbatten overrule him and secure the consent of an overburdened Attlee to rescind the Gilgit lease? Did this action of Mountbatten propel Ismay to sound out Col. Roger Bacon to start planning for the execution of the Gilgit rebellion? Did Ismay also set in motion the return of Sir George Cunningham's third term as the Governor of NWFP from 15 August 1947? Did Ismay take Jinnah into partial or complete confidence about a top-secret plan to invade Jammu and Kashmir if it acceded to India? Was Cunningham a part of this plan? After all, Jinnah did invite Sir George Cunningham in July 1947 to take over as the Governor of NWFP. This appointment cannot be viewed in isolation of the facts emerging.